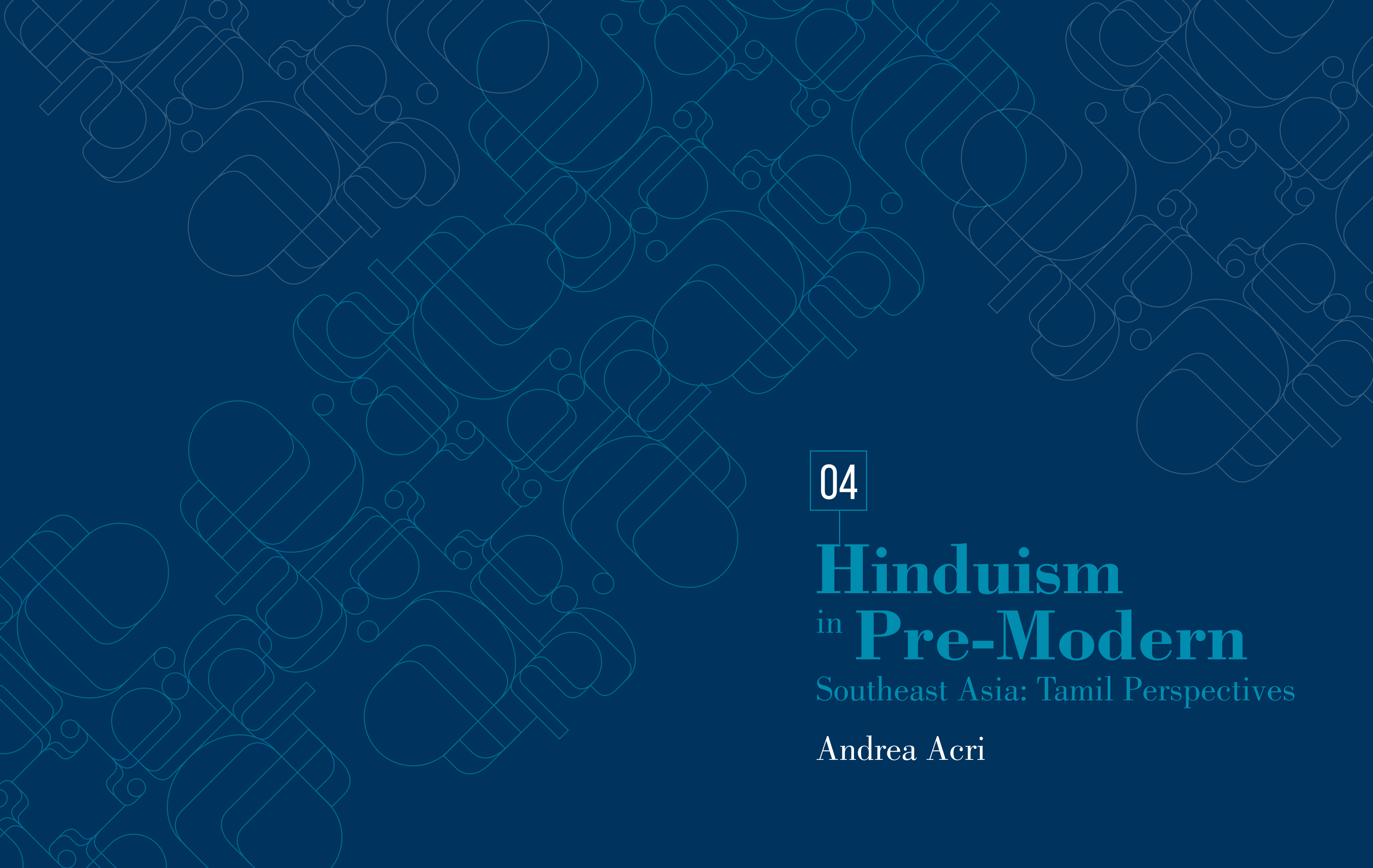




04

Hinduism
in **Pre-Modern**
Southeast Asia: Tamil Perspectives

Andrea Acri



Agastya, Indonesia, 11th century CE.
Courtesy of Indian Heritage Centre.

Introduction

The spread of Indian culture, Sanskrit language, and Hindu¹ beliefs and rituals to Southeast Asia is a complex socio-cultural phenomenon involving the circulation of people, ideas, practices, texts, and icons across the Bay of Bengal from the early centuries of the Common Era (CE) through the “Early Mediaeval” period (the 6th to the 13th centuries CE) and beyond to the colonial and modern periods.² In analysing this phenomenon, and specifically the Tamil contribution to it, scholars have to face multiple problems, including the quantity and nature of available historical data, as well as their interpretation. Early scholars, like the Dutch Indologist Vogel and Indian historian Nilakanta Sastri,³ privileged a Pallava-, Dravidian-, or Tamil-centric perspective, recognising both the geographical proximity of South India to Southeast Asia (especially Sumatra and the Malay Peninsula) and maritime trade (carried out by Tamil traders’ communities) as the main catalysts for cultural transfer. While the important role played by the coastal areas of Southern India and their inhabitants in trans-cultural dynamics across the Bay of Bengal is undeniable, these perspectives were—and still are—often tinged by modern nationalistic biases and regional (that is, “Dravidian”) chauvinism. Indeed, cultural and religious elements that were appropriated by Southeast Asians seem to have come from various regions of the subcontinent over an extended period.⁴ Furthermore, it has increasingly become open to doubt whether trade and traders played a major role in the diffusion of the Indic religious paradigms that contributed to shaping the high cultures of much of Southeast Asia—the various classes of Brahmanical and non-Brahmanical religious and ritual specialists sponsored by the political elites being perhaps better candidates.



South India and Southeast Asia have to be regarded as equal partners in shared civilisational processes.”

Recent theoretical approaches to Indianisation, Sanskritisation, and Hinduisation have sought to transcend the paradigm of a mono-directional influence of India on Southeast Asia by highlighting the agency of Southeast Asians in dynamics of cultural appropriation and multi-directional transfer. They have also emphasised the fact that “India” was not a homogeneous and monolithic entity but a mosaic of variegated regional identities that changed across space and over time. Even more importantly, they have argued that the Sanskritisation of Southeast Asia was not dissimilar from the Sanskritisation of the Indian subcontinent itself, and therefore the process might have occurred “in parallel” across the geographical and socio-cultural entity that Sheldon Pollock⁵ has termed “Sanskrit Cosmopolis”. Therefore, South India and Southeast Asia have to be regarded as equal partners in shared civilisational processes.

Against the background of the theoretical framework outlined above, I shall assess the role of South Indians, and Tamils in particular, in the spread of Brahmanical culture and Hindu religious traditions (mainly Saivism and Vaishnavism) to Southeast Asia from circa the 5th to the 13th centuries CE. In doing so, I shall complement archaeological and art-historical data with literary evidence from pre-modern Java that has been seldom discussed by historians.

Tamil Networks between India and Southeast Asia

Tamils appear to have held a prominent position among the early traders who ventured from India to Southeast Asia, lured by that region’s wealth in minerals and natural products. Available epigraphical evidence suggests that Tamil traders established permanent trading communities overseas, especially at riverine and coastal sites, like Takuapa and Khao Sam Kheo in Thailand, Kedah in the Malay Peninsula, Barus in North Sumatra, and Quanzhou in China. Even though the dissemination of Hindu-Buddhist ideas was imputable probably to South Asian Brahmin priests and Buddhist monks recruited by local kings, the agents and mediums of transmission were inevitably the merchants and their vessels. Therefore, as John Guy notes rightly, “a study of early traces

of Indian merchant activity in the region should provide clues to the early entry of Indic religious systems into the emerging states and kingdoms of Southeast Asia”.⁶

Unfortunately, the epigraphic vestiges at our disposal are scant and mainly documentary in nature, and tell us little about the role of Tamil traders in the transfer of Hinduism to Southeast Asia. On the other hand, many literary sources in Sanskrit and South and Southeast Asian vernaculars tend to present legendary accounts rather than strictly historical information. A fact that would lead us to question the impact of Tamil culture on Southeast Asia is that Tamil’s direct linguistic influence on the region’s pre-modern languages is limited to a few dozen words,⁷ compared to the thousands of attested Sanskrit loanwords. Yet, an important, albeit indirect, clue about the prominent role of South India in cultural transfer is the fact that the near totality of early (4th–7th centuries CE) Sanskrit inscriptions in Southeast Asia are written in the characteristic “box-shaped” script that is often, yet incorrectly, referred to by scholars as “Pallava”, and which could be labelled more accurately “Late Southern Brahmi”.⁸ These inscriptions, written in grammatically correct Sanskrit, are likely to have been composed with the contribution of (Brahminical) scholars from Southern India. On the basis of this assumption, one may speculate that the same scholars could have been responsible for the transmission of religious ideas as well. The earliest Sanskrit inscription from the Indonesian archipelago, the inscribed pillars found in Kutei, Kalimantan (probably 5th–6th centuries CE), mention gifts given by King Mulavarman to Brahmin-officiants.⁹ The Old Javanese Saiva text *Dharma Patanjala*, composed probably before the 10th–11th century CE, refers to Brahmins (along with Persians, Pujut, and Nambi—the last being a Tamil word, and possibly indicating people of Tamil or South Indian origin) as people from overseas whose physical appearance is different, and mentions religious teachings of the people from foreign lands in the same context.¹⁰

Evidence of the involvement of individuals from South India in the spread of Indic religions to Southeast Asia is found in Chinese sources, which, however, record only Buddhist and not Hindu agents. For instance, according to an account by



One of the Yupa inscriptions of Mulavarman. *Courtesy of Kern Institute, Leiden University Library.*

Zanning, the esoteric Buddhist master Vajrabuddhi (671–741 CE) was a Brahmin, son of a royal chaplain (*rajapurohita*) at the court of Kanchi.¹¹ Eminent monks, such as Buddhaghosa, Buddhadutta, Dharmapala, and Nagabuddhi, were also believed to have been natives of South India. While the lack of historical and biographical details in the Sanskrit sources prevents us from knowing the identity of agents of transmission of Hinduism to Southeast Asia, it

could be assumed that the regions of Andhra and Tamil Nadu (especially the port-cities of Nagapattinam as well as Kanchi) were hubs for economic and cultural traffic across the Bay of Bengal. Under the Pallavas, Kanchi was a prime centre of Saivism, and may have acted as an incubator of early tantric doctrinal and ritual systems within both Saiva and Buddhist folds, given the documented presence of proto- and mainstream-tantric Saiva traditions since at least the 7th century CE. Similarly, the port-city of Nagapattinam was dominated by a multi-religious sacred geography.¹² The Kayasivaroohanam/Kayarohanaswami temple is said to have 6th century CE origins, and, as the name suggests, it may have belonged to the Pasupata stream of Saivism, which probably was the earliest form of that religion to have reached Southeast Asia.

Legendary stories of a male ancestor, either a Brahmin or a *Kshatriya*, from India marrying a semi-divine local creature and becoming founder of a royal dynasty are common in Southeast Asia, and resonate with analogous stories associated with the Pallava dynasty found in Tamil literature.¹³ Tamil sources, especially the early Sangam literature, describe the trade links between South India and Kedah on the Malay Peninsula. The Buddhist poem *Manimekalai* describes Kaveripattinam as a bustling trade centre with contacts across the Bay of Bengal, and is aware of the island of Java.¹⁴ The Chinese monk Yijing (635–713 CE) mentions ships sailing between Kedah and Nagapattinam.¹⁵

A handful of Tamil inscriptions have been found in Southeast Asia: four in Sumatra, two on the Malay Peninsula, two in Thailand and one in Myanmar, ranging from the mid-9th to the late-13th centuries CE.¹⁶ While such inscriptions usually do not tell us much about religious matters, some of them are associated with religious remains, while others record donations to temples—thus mirroring similar inscriptions found in Maharashtra and Karnataka in the 12th and 13th centuries CE, and Tamil Nadu in the 13th and 14th centuries CE.¹⁷



Sherd of imported ceramic bearing a Tamil Brahmi inscription. Found in Phu Khao Thong, Ranong province, southern Thailand. *Courtesy of Bérénice Bellina.*

The earliest inscriptions, fragmentary in nature and difficult to interpret, have been found in Thailand as part of pottery sherds going back to the 2nd–3rd centuries CE; one of them could be interpreted as the word for “ascetic” in Old Tamil.¹⁸ An early 9th century CE inscription from a site near the Takuapa river, on the west coast of peninsular Thailand, is associated with the remains of a small religious edifice and three large stone statues of Saiva affiliation, which display Pallava stylistic features. The mention of the foundation of a new tank, named *Sri Avani naranam*, has been linked by Nilakanta Sastri¹⁹ to the reign of the Pallava king Nandivarman III (r. 826–50 CE). It is still open to speculation whether the Hindu activity of the “Indian” settlements on the riverine sites of Bujang valley and Kedah was imputable to South Indians. A probably 7th century CE statue and a head of the male deity Aiyanar, worshiped in Tamil Nadu as early as the 3rd century CE and included later in the Saiva pantheon as a secondary deity, have been found in Central Thailand.²⁰ Aiyanar played the role of guardian of water reservoirs and protector of travellers, and his images have been found in religious sites in India and Sri Lanka.

The Sanskrit inscription of Canggal from Central Java, dated 732 CE, is associated with the erection of a *linga* in a Saiva temple. The ruler and founder of a line of kings, Sanjaya, calls his kingdom Kunjarakunja, which corresponds

to a toponym found also in South India, between Kerala and Tamil Nadu. While the theory posited by scholars that this reference suggests a non-Javanese origin of the ruler has been rightly dismissed, the “transposition” of a South Indian toponym to Java points to cultural contacts between the two areas and the importance of South India in the Javanese imaginary. Analogous dynamics could be detected in a 968 CE Sanskrit inscription from Banteai Srei temple in Angkor (Cambodia), which refers to Jayavarman V’s qualities through allusions to Dakshinapatha (The Southern Path, also meaning ‘Deccan’ in Sanskrit) and Sripavata in the Deccan, suggesting that those were evocative locales in Khmer lands.²¹

From the 10th century CE, the influence of Tamil merchant guilds, such as *manigramam* and *ayyavole* associations, rose across the Bay of Bengal, the South China Sea and Southeast Asia. Javanese inscriptions from the 9th to the 14th centuries CE list various ethnonyms for merchants (some of whom acted also as tax collectors) coming from southern India—the Konkan coast, Orissa, Andhra, and Tamil Nadu.²²

A series of inscriptions and associated material vestiges testify to the existence of religious-cum-diplomatic links between Tamil Nadu and Southeast Asia involving Hindu agents around the 11th century CE. An inscription from the reign of Rajendra Chola records jewels donated to the silver image of Siva by the official of the king of Srivijaya who resided on the coast of Tamil Nadu (referring to the actual Ramanathapuram); another mentions a statue of Siva Ardhanarisvara installed by the official of the king of Kedah, an individual named Sri Kuruttan Kesuvan ana Akralekai, in the Kayarohana temple in Nagapattinam, along with gold coins for worship activities.²³ This evidence complements the records about the Buddhist *vihara* at Nagapattinam built by the son of the king of Srivijaya, Maravijayottungavarman, in honour of his father, Chudamanivarman.²⁴ These epigraphic documents are to be placed in the context of the 11th century CE naval expedition said to have been sent against Srivijaya by the Chola King Rajendra I and its aftermath.

In the Thai-Malay peninsula, archaeological vestiges dating back to the Chola period highlight the role of Tamil merchants

in the patronisation of Hindu temples. A Tamil-Sanskrit bilingual inscription dating to 1258 or 1265 CE, now held in the collection of a Buddhist temple in Nakhom Si Thammarat on the east coast of peninsular Thailand, mentions the river Ganga and records a gift presented by an individual named Danma Senapati to Brahmins.²⁵ Three pieces of probably 10th century CE Chola-style statuary, found in the Vieng Sra-Chaiya region, represent the Hindu deities Vishnu, Surya, and the tantric Batuka-Bhairava.²⁶ Another site in the same province of Nakhom Si Thammarat has yielded remains of a Hindu temple in the late Chola style.²⁷ Architectural elements found at the Lembah Bujang site in Kedah (peninsular Malaysia) also reflect Chola stylistic features.²⁸ Another 13th century CE bilingual Sanskrit-Tamil inscription found near Pagan in Myanmar displays a clear Vaishnava persuasion. It contains opening verses quoted from the *Mukundamala*, a Sanskrit Vaishnava text, and mentions a gift made by Sri Kulasekhara Nambi, a

devotee from Malaimandalam (Cranganore on the Malabar coast) to the Vishnu temple of the Nanadesi merchant association in Pagan.²⁹

An aspect that has often been invoked as proof of South Indian influence is the significant impact of Pallava and Chola art and architecture in Southeast Asia. This influence may go back to Buddhist art of the early site of Amaravati in Andhra. A Pallava influence on Javanese Saiva architecture in the early period (6th–8th centuries) has been detected also,³⁰ but a recent analysis has opened to a multi-centric provenance of motifs beyond the Pallava domains, for instance from the Gupta, Chalukya and later Pala domains.³¹ An evident sign of Tamil influence on the iconography of Hindu temples in mainland Southeast Asia is the representation of the Tamil female Saiva saint Karaikal Ammaiyar in stone lintels of various Khmer sanctuaries, including Banteai Srei (10th century CE).



Lintel of Banteai Srei, Cambodia, with Karaikal Ammaiyar highlighted. *Courtesy of Andrea Acri.*

The Tamil trading community may have been responsible for the adoption of Chola-style images of Buddhas in excavated settlements in Sumatra. Kota Cina was once the seat of a syncretic mercantile Buddhist–Saiva cult imported from Kerala, Tamil Nadu or Sri Lanka from the late 9th to the 12th centuries CE.³² This settlement has yielded a Siva shrine, Vaishnava and Buddhist Chola-style stone imagery, and possibly even stone blocks whose provenance is not local but can be traced to South India.³³ The extent of the penetration of Tamil culture in Sumatra can be appreciated from the existence of toponyms with Tamil affinities (such as Mount Kerinci/Kurinci; Kurinci in the Sangam landscape refers to a mountainous region), Tamil linguistic influences on the vocabulary of the Karo ethnic group, and the existence of sub-clans bearing names associated with the terms Pandya and Chola.³⁴

South Indian Influences on Saivism in Pre-Islamic Java

Saivism was the predominant religion in Java from the mid-9th century CE to the 15th century. The influence of South India on Javanese Saivism is difficult to quantify. Archaeological and art historical evidence cannot be interpreted unequivocally, although Pallava influences are often attributed to the architectural styles of temples as well as to stylistic features of statues of the Saiva pantheon in the Central Javanese period. As far as the religious literature is concerned, namely the Old Javanese texts of the *tutur* and *tattva* genre, which reconfigure Indic linguistic and doctrinal material into a localised framework, little influence seems to have come from the predominantly Tamil-language, non-dual and Vedanta-influenced Saiva Siddhanta that developed in South India from the 12th century CE onwards. Indeed, the Old Javanese texts appear to have affinities with the earlier, and Pan-Indian, form of Saiva Siddhanta based on a Sanskrit corpus of revealed scriptures that has survived to us in manuscripts from South India (mainly Tamil Nadu) and Nepal. The Javanese Saiva Siddhanta constitutes a conglomerate of Saiddhantika



Agastya, Indonesia, 11th century CE.
Courtesy of Indian Heritage Centre.

doctrines displaying an archaic, pre-systematised character, and Pasupata elements, Patanjala yoga, as well as Sankhya and early Vedanta philosophy.

A possible South Indian influence on Pasupata Saivism and its continuation into Saiva Siddhanta in Java is suggested by the presence of Patanjala instead of Lakulisa as the most important member of the Javanese pentad of the

pancakusika or *pancarshi*, regarded as the five children of Siva.³⁵ This motif stems directly from a significant narrative or “foundational myth” of early Saivism known from South Asian Sanskrit sources which narrates the revelation of Pasupata religion in historical times by the Lord through His avatar to four human teachers. In the Indian subcontinent, these four disciples of the Lord’s incarnation, Lakulisa, are regarded as the originators of the four teaching lineages of the Pancarthika Pasupatas. The term Patanjala could be an attempt to make sense of a corrupted form of the original Sanskrit compound *pitanjala* (that is, *pitam+jalam*), ‘he who drank the waters’, which would be an epithet of Agastya referring to the mythological episode of his drinking of the ocean.³⁶ As a matter of fact, if in the Northern part of the Indian subcontinent, Lakulisa was considered the first and most prominent teacher and an incarnation of Siva, the sage Agastya was the Adiguru of the Dravidian South.³⁷ A textual passage suggesting an identification of Agastya as an emanation of Siva is found in the South Indian Saiddhantika text *Purvakaranagama* (26.3cd–4ab), where the sage appears as the last and most important member of the pentad formed by the Rishis and Adisaivas Kausika, Kasyapa, Bharadvaja, Gautama, and Agastya, who have been consecrated in the five faces of Sadasiva.³⁸ Thus, Patanjala was seen in Java as a manifestation of the Supreme Lord, just like in Tamil Nadu, and Agastya was considered an emanation of Siva (as Bhatara Guru). Being the ‘cultural hero’ who authored the first Tamil grammar and introduced Brahmanism, Agastya also holds a prominent position in traditional accounts of the diffusion of Saivism in the Tamil country. For instance, the Old Tamil Saiva poem *Tirumantiram* by Tirumular (2.1.1–2) mentions Agastya as the first hero who transmitted Saivism to the South. Agastya (and his alter-ego Patanjala) may have been connected with the introduction of Saivism in Java, and, perhaps, elsewhere in Southeast Asia, too.³⁹

Whereas in Java Agastya holds a position of great prominence in iconography, becoming a sort of quintessential Brahmin bearing the attributes of the Rishi

group, neither textual occurrences of the name Lakulisa nor iconographic representations have been found in the archipelago thus far. Lakulisa became a prominent figure only in the Northwestern part of the Indian subcontinent from the 6th century CE onwards. Therefore, Lakulisa may have been replaced in Java by the more familiar ‘Southern’ figure of Agastya in order to enhance the status of the doctrine, or perhaps there existed already an independent Pasupata tradition in Southern India, which may have been a hub for the transmission of Pasupata Saivism to Java.

A passage in the Old Javanese *Ramayana Kakavin* (ca. mid-9th–early 10th century CE) suggests that South Indian religious groups may have been familiar to its contemporary Javanese audience. Lines 24cd of Sarga 25 allegorically describes peacocks as members of the religious group of the Kaumaras, the worshipers of the warrior-god—and Siva’s son—Kumara (also known as Skanda or Kartikeya), who were popular in South India and the Tamil land in particular. The peacock is both the vehicle (*vahana*) and banner of Siva’s son. The stanza runs as follows:⁴⁰

*aji sang kumara ajining mrak arum majule makuñcir
agələm mangigəl. (25.24cd)*

*The teaching of the illustrious Kumara is the teaching of
the graceful peacocks: acting thoughtlessly, [they] wear a
tuft on the top of the head, and dance without stop.*

The reference to continuous dance may allude to the dances of devotional characters performed in honour of Kumara by Kaumara practitioners. The *Tirumurukarruppatai*, a probably 6th–7th century CE Sangam Tamil poem devoted to the worship of Skanda/Murugan, describes the *kuravai* dance as follows: “hillmen dance the *kuravai* to the *tontaka* drum, inebriated by the liquor made from honey, which matured in the long bamboos” (194–197).⁴¹ The *kuravai* is, in the poem, implicitly linked to Murugan, and the *Kalittokai* makes an explicit reference to the religious significance of the dance, which is done “to please the god who lives on the mountains.” On the basis of his analysis of the early and later strata of

the Sangam poetic corpus, Hardy⁴² expressed the opinion that “the poetry is dealing with a *real* dance form of the ancient Tamils, or better, that behind the poetic coding a real dance may be assumed.” He deduced that at least three varieties of *kuravai* were performed by priests and laity of both sexes, and that the sources agree on the whole on the orgiastic, wild and ecstatic character of the dance. Analogous dances, like the *kavadi attam*, are associated with the movements of peacocks, and the *kavadi*-frame itself is adorned with peacock feathers.

Many elements of the Tamil dances described above resonate with the image portrayed in the *Ramayana Kakavin*. (*Ma*)*kuncir*, a rare Old Javanese word that is attested only in *Ramayana Kakavin* 5.65 and 25.24, means “crest”. (Compare Bahasa Indonesia *kuncir*, “cowlick”, being related perhaps to *kuncit*, “a crest or tuft on the back of the head”?)⁴³ It might thus allude to the crest on the head of the peacock and, at the same time, to the “crest-hair” or tuft worn by Kaumara practitioners. Since the *kuravai* dance is in Tamil Sangam poems often connected to “hillmen” (*kurinci*) and to a mountainous setting, *kuncir* might constitute concomitantly an anagram evocating the Old Tamil word *kurinci*.⁴⁴ The form *majule* “inattentive, thoughtless, frivolous, empty-headed”, may refer to the clichéd behaviour of “drunken” or “intoxicated” peacocks, and to the fact that the Kaumaras danced wildly—in a trance or possession, or under the effect of liquor. Although it is difficult to ascertain whether the stanza reflects clichés found in Sanskrit literature or an actual knowledge by the Javanese poet(s), the verse quoted above suggests that Tamil socio-cultural and religious elements were recognisable realities in the imaginary of Javanese elites.

Circumstantial literary evidence suggests that South India played a role in influencing East Javanese Saivism during the late Majapahit kingdom. Teeuw *et al.*⁴⁵ hypothesised the existence of contacts between the South Indian kingdom of Vijayanagara and the kingdom of Majapahit in East Java from the 14th to the late-15th centuries, when both areas experienced some sort of “Hindu revival” as a

response to the growing threat from Islam. Mpu Prapanca’s 14th century CE *Kakavin Desavarnana*, known also under its Javano-Sanskrit title *Nagarakrtagama*, mentions the presence of Indian literati at the court of the East Javanese King Rajasanagara: Buddhaditya from Kanchipuram (which at that time had already been annexed to Vijayanagara), and the Brahmin Mutali.⁴⁶ Two important works—*Sivaratrikalpa*, a religious poem, and the *Vrttasancaya*, a work dealing with prosody—by the poet Mpu Tanakung, who was active in late 15th century Java, betray first-hand acquaintance with Indian material. His direct source for part of the *Sivaratrikalpa* appears to have been a version of the Indian *Padmapurana*, while for the *Vrttasancaya*, he seems to have used several Sanskrit works.⁴⁷ The ritual of *Sivaratri*, well known in India, appears in the Archipelago for the first time in the *Sivaratrikalpa*. The latter text betrays other relatively late South Indian doctrinal influences.⁴⁸

A concrete piece of evidence suggesting a relatively late South Indian line of transmission for an early Sanskrit Siddhantatantra to Java and/or Bali is constituted by a quotation of a verse of the *Kiranatantra* in the Sanskrit-Old Javanese text *Jnanasiddhanta*, which has come down to us in Balinese palm-leaf manuscripts. Remarkably, the second half-verse is not found in all the ancient Nepalese manuscripts and also in the commentary by 11th century CE Kashmiri exegete Ramakantha, but it appears in the later South Indian redactions, such as the edition published in Devakottai (Tamil Nadu). Since some of these redactions may have been compiled even after the 12th century CE, we may assume that this verse was borrowed in that form either from a South Indian recension of the *Kirana* or from another version that had come after Ramakantha.⁴⁹

Conclusion

Tamil individuals, possibly religious specialists, as well as communities of traders, may have contributed to the transfer of religious ideas and practices across the Bay of

Bengal from the early centuries of the first millennium to the 13th century CE. Still, it remains difficult to assess the overall impact of these individuals and communities on Hindu beliefs and practices in Southeast Asia, for the region received influences from different areas of the Indian subcontinent across a wide time span. In the light of this consideration, the idea developed by early 20th century scholarship about the pre-eminent role of South India, and the Tamil country in particular, in shaping the artistic and cultural paradigm of the pre-modern Indic societies of Southeast Asia should probably be revisited. The linguistic evidence is somehow ambiguous. On the one hand, South India appears to have played a primary role in the transfer of Indic script to Southeast Asia, as witnessed by the fact that many pre-modern Southeast Asian scripts evolved from a form of South Indian Brahmi. On the other hand, the influence of Tamil and other South Indian vernaculars on Southeast Asian languages is limited, Sanskrit being the cosmopolitan language *par excellence* over much of Southeast Asia in the pre-modern period. Limited but nonetheless interesting evidence of possible Tamil influences on Old Javanese belletristic and Saiva texts exists, but more research in this largely unexplored field is needed to confirm preliminary findings. The likewise limited finds in Southeast Asia of Hindu statuary and other motifs bearing South Indian (Pallava or Chola) features, as well as epigraphic documents in Tamil, suggest that these artefacts and written documents may have been meant for restricted use within the communities of South Indian merchants. Indeed, the extent of the interactions between members of these communities and society outside their enclaves is still uncertain, except in the case of Sumatra, where wider-ranging cultural exchanges with the local populations seem to have taken place. As noted by Christie,⁵⁰ the impact of these communities on trade has been regarded as being limited both temporally and geographically, for clearly the majority of traders in the region were from Southeast Asia as well as other regions of the Indian subcontinent and Central Asia.

A fascinating but still far from settled chapter in the narrative of Tamil cultural influences in Southeast Asia has to do with

the 11th century CE Chola raids in Sumatra and the Malay Peninsula. In spite of their short-lived and circumscribed impact on local socio-political realities, these expeditions nonetheless could have been catalysts for farther-reaching developments in the religious sphere, as suggested by the existence of religious endowments and icons in the context of diplomatic contacts between the Cholas and the ruling elites in the Srivijayan domains.

Tamils have played a primary role in the shaping of current paradigms in much of the Hindu diasporic communities in modern Southeast Asia, although a certain cultic segregation on the basis of social, linguistic and geographical categories still exists. In Thailand, the Tamil influence on the indigenised communities of Brahmins who act as ritualists for the royal palace could be traced back to the early modern period, while in Malaysia, Singapore and Sumatra, Tamil Hindu communities have been built as a result of immigration that occurred from the colonial period onwards. Tamil Hindu festivals such as *Thaipusam*, *Deepavali*, *Pongal*, *Theemiti* (fire-walking festival) and other festivals dedicated to Murugan are celebrated in Malaysia and Singapore, where the majority of Hindus are of Tamil or other South Indian background. The mainstream current of Hinduism practised by these communities can be considered a form of Saiva Siddhanta with a strong Tamil coloration, imported probably by Chettiars and Ceylonese Tamils. Many of the modern Hindu temples in Southeast Asia are dedicated to Tamil deities such as Sri Mariamman and Murugan, alongside mainstream Saiva and Hindu deities.

Notes to Chapters

Notes to Chapter 4:

Hinduism in Pre-Modern Southeast Asia: Tamil Perspectives

1. In this chapter I use the term “Hinduism” for the sake of convenience, being fully aware of the fact that this etic and relatively late term does not reflect the situation of pre-modern South and Southeast Asia, where “Saiva”, “Vaishnava” and “Sakta” cults existed within the wider social framework of Brahmanism.

2. Areas where Hinduism is the dominant religion, or where Hindu communities from the pre-modern period survive to this day, are the island of Bali and the Tengger highlands of East Java in Indonesia, as well as the Cham region of Southern Vietnam.

3. J. Ph. Vogel, “The Yūpa Inscriptions of King Mūlavarman, from Koetei (East Borneo)”, *Bijdragen van het Koninklijk Instituut voor Taal-, Land-en Volkenkunde* 74 (1918): 167–233; Nilakanta Sastri, *South Indian Influences in the Far East*. Bombay: Hind Kitabs, 1949.

4. The same conclusion has been drawn by A. Sanderson, “Śaivism among the Khmers; Part I”, *Bulletin de l’École française d’Extrême-Orient* 90–91 (2003-04), 444ff, in his study of Saivism among the Khmers: the ancient Cambodian sources present influences that cannot be ascribed uniquely to, for example, South India or Bengal. Similarly, the versions of the *Mahabharata* found in Southeast Asia cannot be ascribed uniquely to the Northern or Southern recensions.

5. Sheldon Pollock, *The Language of the Gods in the World of Men: Sanskrit, Culture, and Power in Premodern India* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2006).

6. J. Guy, *Lost Kingdoms: Hindu-Buddhist Sculpture of Early Southeast Asia* (New York: The Metropolitan Museum of Art, 2014), 243.

7. On Tamil and Malayalam loanwords in pre-modern Western Malayo-Polynesian languages, see T. Hoogervorst, “Detecting pre-modern lexical influence from South India in Maritime Southeast Asia”, *Archipel* 89 (2015), 63–93.

8. A. Griffiths, “Early Indic Inscriptions of Southeast Asia”, in *Lost Kingdoms: Hindu-Buddhist Sculpture of Early Southeast Asia*, edited by. J. Guy (New York: The Metropolitan Museum of Art, 2014), 55.

9. Vogel, “The Yūpa Inscriptions of King Mūlavarman, from Koetei (East Borneo)”.

10. A. Acri, *Dharma Pātañjala; A Śaiva Scripture from Ancient Java Studied in the Light of Related Old Javanese and Sanskrit Texts*, Second Edition (Delhi: Aditya Prakashan, 2017), 208–210.

11. Orzech. C, “Vajrabodhi,” In *Esoteric Buddhism and the Tantras in East Asia*, edited by C.D. Orzech, H.H. Sørensen, and R.K. Payne, (Leiden/Boston: Brill, 2011), 346.

12. Indeed, we know that both Kanchi and Nagapattinam hosted Pasupata temples, and South Indian sources like the farce *Mattavilasa*, composed in Kanchi in the 7th century CE, mention Pasupata and Kapalika ascetics. Furthermore, an early attestation of the word *saivasiddhanta* is found in the 8th century CE inscription around the base of the main shrine in the Kailasanatha temple in Kanchi: see D. Goodall, *The Parākhyatantra. A Scripture of the Śaiva Siddhānta: A Critical Edition and Annotated Translation* (Pondicherry: Institut Français de Pondichéry/École française d’Extrême-Orient, 2004), xix, note 17.

13. Sastri, *South Indian Influences in the Far East*, 59.

14. S. Lévi, “Manimekhala, a Divinity of the Sea,” *The Indian Historical Quarterly* 4 (1930), 597–614.

15. J. Takakusu, *A Record of the Buddhist religion as practised in India and the Malay Archipelago, I-Tsing* (A.D. 671–695) (Delhi: Munshiram Manoharlal, 1966, Reprint of 1896 edition, London: Clarendon Press), xlv.

16. J. Christie, “The Medieval Tamil-Language Inscriptions in Southeast Asia and China”, *Journal of Southeast Asian Studies* 29, no. 2 (1998), 239–68.

17. N. Karashima, “South Indian Merchant Guilds in the Indian Ocean and Southeast Asia”, in *Nagapattinam to Suvarnadwipa: Reflections on the Chola Naval Expeditions to Southeast Asia*, edited by H. Kulke, K. Kesavapany and V. Sakhuja, Singapore: ISEAS, 2009, 135–137.

18. B. Bellina, “Southeast Asia and the Early Maritime Silk Road,” in Guy, *Lost Kingdoms*, 274, fn. 11. However, alternative readings suggested to Bellina by Manu Francis would be “common black plum” or “plum recipient” (see Ibid.). In a letter to the editors of this volume, Prof. K. Rajan suggested that this may be the personal name *turava[ṇ]*, and that the date of the inscribed potsherd could be placed before the 2nd–1st century BCE.

19. Sastri, *South Indian Influences in the Far East*, 90.

20. Guy, *Lost Kingdoms: Hindu-Buddhist Sculpture of Early Southeast Asia*, 184–185.

21. Sastri, *South Indian Influences in the Far East*, 43; G. Coédès, *Inscriptions du Cambodge*, vol. 1. Hanoi: *Imprimerie d’Extrême-Orient*, 1937, 149, line 7. Another inscription issued during the reign of Indravarman I (878–887 CE) describes the royal guru Sivasoma as having “learnt the *śāstras* from him who is known as Bhagavan Śāṅkara, and whose lotus feet are licked by the row of bees, i.e. the heads of all scholars” (Sastri, *South Indian Influences in the Far East*). Coédès, *Inscriptions du Cambodge*, 37, notes that it is not impossible that this coincides with the famous Sankaracharya, who was active in South India in the early 9th century CE (but whom more recent scholarship dates rather to the early 8th century CE, thus making Coédès’ identification unlikely).

22. Christie, “The Medieval Tamil-Language Inscriptions in Southeast Asia and China”.

23. G. Seshadri, “New Perspectives on Nagapattinam: The Medieval Port City in the Context of Political, Religious, and Commercial Exchanges between South India, Southeast Asia, and China”, in *Nagapattinam to Suvarnadwipa*, 121–124.

24. Ibid., 125.

25. Christie, “The Medieval Tamil-Language Inscriptions in Southeast Asia and China,” 265.

26. S.J. O’Connor, *Hindu Gods of Peninsular Siam (Artibus Asiae*, Supplementum, vol. 28), 1972, 59–60, and figs. 32–34.

27. J. Guy, “Tamil Merchants and the Hindu-Buddhist Diaspora in Early Southeast Asia”, in *Early Interactions between South and Southeast Asia: Reflections on Cross-cultural Exchange* eds. P.-Y. Manguin, A. Mani and G. Wade. Singapore: ISEAS Publishing, 2011, 255.

28. Ibid., 256. Commercial activities and religious sponsorship of Tamil merchants extended to South China, as suggested by the bilingual Tamil and Chinese language inscription dated to 1281 CE found in Quanzhou, which is associated with remains of one of the two Siva temples found in the region: R. Lee, “Constructing Community: Tamil Merchant Temples in India and China, 850–1281”, PhD diss., Columbia University, 2012.

29. Christie, “The Medieval Tamil-Language Inscriptions in Southeast Asia and China,” 265–66.

30. J.C. Harle, *The Art and Architecture of the Indian Subcontinent*, Second Edition (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1994), 280–83.

31. J. Romain, “Indian Architecture in the ‘Sanskrit Cosmopolis’: The Temples of the Dieng Plateau”, in *Early Interactions between South and Southeast Asia*, edited by P.-Y. Manguin, A. Mani, and G. Wade (Singapore: ISEAS, 2011), 299–316.

32. E. Edwards-McKinnon, “Continuity and Change in South Indian Involvement in Northern Sumatra: The Inference of Archeological Evidence from Kota Cina and Lamreh”, in *Early Interactions between South and Southeast Asia*, 138.

33. Ibid., 141.

34. Ibid., 143.

35. A. Acri, “Pañcakuśika and Kanda Mpat. From a Pāśupata Śaiva Myth to Balinese Folklore”, *Journal of Hindu Studies* 7, no. 2 (2014): 146–178.

36. A. Sanderson, “Śaivism among the Khmers; Part I”, *Bulletin de l’École française d’Extrême-Orient* 90–91 (2003–04): 374–375.

37. J. Filliozat, “Agastya et la propagation du Brahmanisme au Sud-Est Asiatique”, *The Adyar Library Bulletin* 31–32 [Dr. V. Raghavan Felicitation Volume] (1967): 447.

38. Ibid., 448.

39. A perhaps 8th–9th century CE copper statuette of Agastya in its quintessentially Brahmanic iconography has been found in Perak Malay Peninsula, and another one in northeastern Thailand (Guy, *Lost Kingdoms*, 185). The fragmentary inscription, written in Sanskrit in a “Pallava”-derived script, of Wat Maheyong (Tha Sala), discovered in Nakhon si Thammarat (Thailand) and dateable to between the 7th and the 9th centuries CE refers to gifts to the Buddhist community but also to Brahmins of the community of Agastya (M. Jacq-Hergoualc’h, T. Srisuchat, T. Supajanya, and W. Krisanapol, “La région de Nakhon Si Thammarat (Thaïlande péninsulaire) du V au XIV siècle”, *Journal Asiatique* 284, no. 2 (1996): 378).

40. S. Santoso, ed. *Rāmāyaṇa Kakawin*, 3 vols (New Delhi: International Academy of Indian Culture, 1980).

41. F. Hardy, *Viraha-Bhakti: The Early History of Kṛṣṇa Devotion in South India* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1983), 618.

42. Ibid., 620.

43. P.J. Zoetmulder, *Old Javanese-English Dictionary* (with the collaboration of S.O. Robson), (The Hague: M. Nijhoff, 1982), 927.

44. The whole Sarga 25 abounds in double-entendres and other sophisticated figures of speech.

45. A. Teeuw, Th. P. Galestin, S.O. Robson, P.J. Worsley and P.J. Zoetmulder (eds. and trans.), *Śiwarātrikalpa of Mpu Tanakung; An Old Javanese Poem, its Indian Source and Balinese Illustrations* (The Hague: Nijhoff, 1969), 19.

46. S. Robson, *Deśawarṇana (Nagarakṛtāgama) by Mpu Prapanca* (Leiden: KITLV Press, 1995), 193.

47. T. Hunter, “Wṛttasañcaya Reconsidered”, *Bijdragen tot de Taal-, Land- en Volkenkunde* 157 (2001): 65–96.

48. M. Nihom, “*Dikṣā, Kalā* and the *Stuti* of Śiwarātrikalpa 33.1–2”, *Bijdragen tot de Taal-, Land- en Volkenkunde* 153 (1997): 103–11.

49. A. Acri, “The Sanskrit-Old Javanese Tutar Literature from Bali. The Textual Basis of Saivism in Ancient Indonesia”, *Rivista di Studi Sudasiatici* 1 (2006): 119–120.

50. Christie, “The Medieval Tamil-Language Inscriptions in Southeast Asia and China”, 267.